



The Coach Who Won Everything but the Last Game

Teacher copy (everything in the student copy, plus answers and teaching notes)

The article, marked for rhetorical devices (one color throughout):

1 Rick Adelman died on June 1, sixteen days short of his eightieth birthday. He won 1,042 games as an NBA coach, the tenth most in the history of the league. He never won a championship.

2 Those two facts sat beside each other for his whole career, and they sit beside each other still. The ring is the loud thing, the thing the highlight reels are cut for, the thing a city throws a parade around. The win total is the quiet thing, accumulated one ordinary Tuesday at a time over twenty-three seasons. [Antithesis] Adelman gave his life to the quiet thing. Twice the loud one came within reach, and twice it went elsewhere: Portland lost the 1990 Finals to Detroit in five, then lost the 1992 Finals to Chicago in six.

3 What he had instead was reach. He coached the Trail Blazers, the Warriors, the Kings, the Rockets, the Timberwolves. In Sacramento he made the playoffs eight straight years and took six division titles; in Houston, after Yao Ming broke his foot a dozen games into a 22-game winning streak, his team still finished 55-27. [Juxtaposition] He had been a journeyman point guard before any of it, 7.7 points a night across five teams in six seasons, the kind of player nobody builds a statue for. That part of the record is just true. It explains nothing and it stays.

4 On April 6, 2013, in Minnesota, he beat the Pistons 107-101 and became the eighth coach ever to reach a thousand wins. He was not a man who performed for the room. The voice was level, the manner plain, the teams better than their rosters had any right to be, season after season after season. [Cumulative and periodic sentences]

5 Only four coaches in league history won more games at a higher rate, and their names are Riley, Popovich, Sloan, Karl. To stand just behind that company, and to have stood there without ever once being the loudest man in the building, is its own kind of monument. [Antithesis] The Hall of Fame agreed in 2021.

6 His son David coaches the Denver Nuggets now, and learned the work at his father's side in Minnesota. The teaching did not stop; it changed offices. A thousand and forty-two wins, and not one of them the one everyone counts first. He would have told you the count was never the point. The work was. [Telegraphic sentence]

Devices, and why they are here:

Antithesis (paragraph 2): “The ring is the loud thing, the thing the highlight reels are cut for, the thing a city throws a parade around. The win total is the quiet thing, accumulated one ordinary Tuesday at a time over twenty-three seasons.”

Sets the ring (loud, ceremonial) against the win total (quiet, accumulated) in balanced form. This is the controlling opposition of the whole piece, established early so the reader can name both poles after one read.

Juxtaposition (paragraph 3): “In Sacramento he made the playoffs eight straight years and took six division titles; in Houston, after Yao Ming broke his foot a dozen games into a 22-game winning streak, his team still finished 55-27.”

Places the eight-year Sacramento run beside the Houston streak survived without an injured star, letting two unlike achievements sit side by side to show the breadth of his durability rather than arguing for it.

Cumulative and periodic sentences (paragraph 4): “The voice was level, the manner plain, the teams better than their rosters had any right to be, season after season after season.”

A cumulative sentence: the base clause states a plain fact, then trailing parallel members pile the character behind it, so the qualities accrue by accumulation rather than being asserted.

Antithesis (paragraph 5): “To stand just behind that company, and to have stood there without ever once being the loudest man in the building, is its own kind of monument.”

Pits standing among the all-time greats against never being the loudest presence, converting restraint itself into the measure of greatness, the engine's small-versus-large turned to its peak.

Telegraphic sentence (paragraph 6): “The work was.”

A three-word sentence lands the whole piece on the quiet pole of its antithesis, giving the close a flat snap instead of a sentimental flourish.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. Which of the following best characterizes the writer's position on Adelman's lack of a championship?
 - A) It is a failure the writer works to excuse on Adelman's behalf
 - B) It is a defining absence the writer treats as secondary to the larger record of sustained excellence
 - C) It is a misfortune the writer blames on the teams that beat him
 - D) It is an oversight the writer argues the Hall of Fame should have weighed more heavily
2. In the third paragraph, the writer places the eight-year Sacramento playoff run beside Houston finishing 55-27 after Yao Ming's injury primarily to
 - A) demonstrate the breadth of his durability across different rosters
 - B) establish the loud-versus-quiet opposition the whole tribute is built on
 - C) attribute the strong Houston record to Yao Ming's eventual return
 - D) prove he was the most adaptable coach of his era

Multiple choice answer key:

1. Answer B. The opener names the missing title plainly and repeatedly, then subordinates it to the 1,042 wins and the decades of overperforming rosters, ending on 'the count was never the point. The work was.' The option about excusing the failure inverts the writer's stance, which never apologizes but reframes; it fails by inverted relationship. The option blaming the opposing teams imports a grievance the text does not raise, naming Detroit and Chicago only as neutral fact; it fails by out-of-passage import. The option about the Hall of Fame is true-but-not-asked, since the Hall is mentioned as agreement, not as having erred.

2. Answer A. The two records sit side by side without comment so the reader registers that the same coach succeeded under unlike conditions, the durability the paragraph is built to show. The option about the loud-versus-quiet opposition names a real effect, but that opposition is set up in the second paragraph, not in this side-by-side of two records; it fails as right effect, wrong location. The option calling him the most adaptable coach of his era inflates the paragraph into a ranking the text never makes; it fails as over-broad. The option crediting Yao Ming's return reverses the point, since the 55-27 finish is offered as something achieved despite the injury, with no return mentioned; it fails by inverted relationship.

Discussion questions:

1. The piece never states in plain words that Adelman was great; it arranges facts so the reader concludes it. Where does the writing do this work, and is the indirect method more or less persuasive than simply asserting his greatness?
2. The closing lines distinguish 'the count' from 'the work.' What is the difference the writer draws between them, and how does the rest of the opener prepare that distinction?

Sample strong discussion responses:

1. The writer builds the case through placement rather than praise. The opening sets three flat facts next to each other, the wins and the missing ring, and lets their friction do the arguing. The Sacramento and Houston facts in the third paragraph show breadth without the writer ever calling it impressive; the reader supplies that judgment. The antithesis of loud and quiet gives the reader a frame to measure by, and by the time the names Riley, Popovich, Sloan, and Karl appear, the conclusion that Adelman belongs near them feels discovered, not handed over. Indirection is more persuasive here because a tribute that argues sounds defensive, and Adelman's whole appeal is that he never argued for himself either.
2. The count is the championship and the round number of wins, the thing scoreboards and obituaries lead with. The work is the daily, unglamorous labor of making mediocre rosters into playoff teams for twenty-three years. The opener prepares this split from its first lines, holding the title against the win total, then keeps widening it: the journeyman playing career that 'explains nothing and stays,' the teams 'better than their rosters had any right to be.' By the close, the reader has been shown so much work and so little spectacle that when the writer says the count was never the point, the sentence reads as earned rather than asserted.

Writing prompt (Homework or extended in-class, Q2 rhetorical analysis):

The following passage is a tribute published after the death of Hall of Fame NBA coach Rick Adelman in June 2026. Read the passage carefully. Then write an essay that analyzes the rhetorical choices the writer makes to honor Adelman and to shape the reader's understanding of his career. In your response you should: respond to the prompt with a defensible thesis that analyzes the writer's rhetorical choices; select and use evidence to support your line of reasoning; explain how the evidence supports your line of reasoning; and demonstrate an understanding of the rhetorical situation. Consider, among other choices, the writer's use of antithesis, sentence structure, and the placement of facts.

Common misconceptions to watch for:

- Students may label the loud-versus-quiet contrast in paragraph 2 as a metaphor. The 'loud thing' and 'quiet thing' are the framing of an antithesis (a balanced contrast of two opposed ideas), not a single implied comparison of one object to another; the contrast, not the figurative naming, is the load-bearing move.
- Students may call the marked closing line in paragraph 6 ('The work was.') simply 'short syntax.' The controlled vocabulary asks for the specific device: a very short sentence, roughly under five words, used to land a point, named a telegraphic sentence, not the umbrella term syntax.
- Students may read the missing championship as the writer's main argument or as a flaw the writer is defending. The opener treats the absence as fact and reframes it; mistaking reframing for either complaint or apology misreads the consecratory stance.
- Students may treat the journeyman playing stats as evidence building toward a point. The writer flags that detail as one that 'explains nothing and it stays,' an inert true fact, so reading it as load-bearing proof misjudges its function.

AP exam alignment:

This opener teaches antithesis as a structural engine rather than a one-line ornament, showing how a single sustained opposition (loud achievement against quiet accumulation) can organize an entire passage. It also models how a writer establishes significance by placement and concrete fact rather than by asserting importance, and gives students a clean case for a Q2 rhetorical-analysis essay on the consecratory (tribute) mode, where the rhetorical situation is to honor rather than to argue against an opponent.